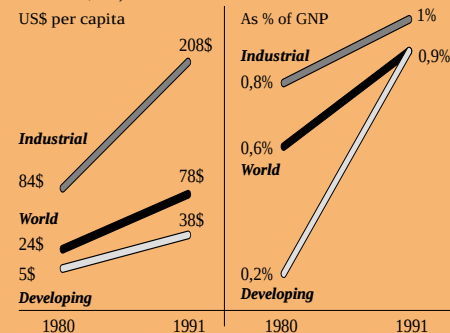


Cultural Trade On the Rise

Global trade in cultural goods* increased from \$67 billion in 1980 to \$196,5 billion in 1991.



*Printed matter, literature, music, visual arts, cinema, photography, radio and television. Source: World Culture Report.

between different national communities, especially in a context of growing bilateral trade. An example that deserves attention is the Mexico-United States Trusteeship for Culture, a body set up by the Rockefeller Foundation, the National Foundation for Culture and the Arts (a Mexican public body) and

a bank institution. Aimed at enhancing cultural exchange, the Trusteeship grants financial support every year to bilateral projects in all fields of the arts. Interviews with artists and institutions which had received support not only pointed to the stimulating impact of these day-to-day contacts, but also what each society values in the art of the other, with a tendency by the United States to ignore Mexico's creativity in recent decades. The value of encounters, workshops and comparative studies to help the different regions take advantage of innovations made elsewhere and better understand the transformations afoot in the artistic, publishing and communications industries cannot be underestimated. By advancing in this direction, cultural policies could set about creating new forms of inter- and multicultural cooperation in which national and foreign cultures develop side by side, in mutual enhancement.

Nestor García Canclini
Autonomous Metropolitan University
of Mexico

Indonesia's Gamelan: Beyond World Music

Indonesia's gamelan music may well be considered as World Music – a marketing category coined by record-industry executives in the 1980s – but to simply regard it as a cultural commodity available in the large record stores of western capitals is to overlook a rich array of cultural practices extending well beyond the commercial domain. Gamelan has become a global music, composed performed and taught in many parts of the world, by Indonesians and non-Indonesians alike.

Transcending classes

A gamelan ensemble is a set of tuned percussion instruments, usually made of bronze, typically comprising gongs of various sizes, metallophones, drums and other instruments (violins, flutes and zither). Played throughout the islands of Bali and Java, gamelan has a popular and classical tradition: while community gamelan groups have been a central part of everyday village life, gamelan orchestras also occupied an important position in the elaborate Javanese court culture which developed in the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries.

Gamelan has gone on to become a national cultural institution in Indonesia, fully integrated into the modern media landscape. Performances of gamelan music –

sometimes including western drum kits or synthesizers – are regularly broadcast on Indonesian radio and TV networks, and gamelan is ubiquitous in everyday media culture, from advertising to fashion shows. It also plays a key role in Indonesia's multi-billion dollar tourist industry: while in its traditional form gamelan was primarily an accompaniment to a temple ceremony, a wedding or an all-night puppet show, it is now a full-fledged performance, staged for the benefit of western tourists.

A hybrid touch

Indonesia's pop music has added another hybrid, modern touch to gamelan: just as Western musicians have been incorporating sampled ethnic musics into their own works since the 1960s, Indonesian pop sometimes uses sampled gamelan music. Combining the gamelan orchestra with western instruments is no simple matter however, since both the tuning and scales of gamelan instruments are different from those of western ones. One ingenious solution to this problem was found by the producer of the Sundanese pop singer Detty Kurnia, who in several of her recordings, combines traditional gamelan instruments with a sampled chromatic-scale gamelan adapted to the western keyboard. ▶▶

THE MUSIC INDUSTRY

Ever since the emergence of the long-playing record in the 1950s, the music industry has been a global phenomenon. Today, more than 80% of the world market is controlled by the so-called Big Six transnational corporations: Sony (Japan), Polygram (Netherlands); Warner (United States), BMG (Germany), Thorn EMI (UK) and MCA (Japan). Data from the International Federation of the Phonographic Industry (IFPI) indicate that the global value of reported retail sales in 1996 was almost \$40 billion. Between 1986 and 1996, retail sales value rose by 7% per annum in real terms, with relatively slower growth in the United States and Western Europe, and more rapid growth rates in Eastern Europe, Latin America, Asia and Africa/Middle East. In most cases, music from the Third World has been brought to wider attention through the activities of independent record producers. Pirating is a major concern, with worldwide pirate sales in 1995 amounting to over \$2.1 billion.

The West's encounter with the genre began about a century ago with Claude Debussy's discovery of Javanese gamelan music at the 1889 World Fair in Paris. Later, in the 1950s, American composers such as Lou Harrison, John Cage and Steve Reich began composing works for various combinations of gamelan and Western instruments, from clarinets to electric guitars. But it is only recently that gamelan has broken out of academic circles to become a feature on the World Music circuit, although not in the hybridized form it has taken on in Indonesia. Instead, with the expansion of the World Music market in the 1990s, one of the industry's responses has been to turn increasingly to the vast and largely untapped archive of ethnomusicological field recordings. *Music of the Gods* is one example. Released four years ago, it features digitally restored gamelan music recorded in the early 1940s by two Americans. With the Library of Congress's name on the cover, scholarly liner notes and a bibliography, this is clearly not your average Angélique Kidjo CD. While the album's producers acknowledged the vitality of gamelan music today, they express anxieties about the recent impact of tourism on gamelan performance. Yet their claims to presenting "authentic" gamelan music to consumers should be tempered. People have been complaining about tourists in Bali since the 1930s, and there is little reason to believe that the earliest recordings made by foreigners were any less staged than contemporary Balinese music put on for tourists.

© SIPA PRESS/LATITAS



A lively and evolving tradition

This focus on the local and traditional is an irony, as if global modernity had not happened. And yet, the dissonance of gamelan tuning and scales in relation to their Western counterparts serves as an apt metaphor: gamelan cannot be reduced to the commercial dimension of the global music industry, which tends to ignore a modern, hybridized form of gamelan. Rather than metaphorically try to retune it to fit western models, we would do better to listen more attentively to its musical and cultural dissonance, reflect on the limitations of our own scales of value and meaning, and recalibrate them accordingly.

Martin Roberts
New School for Social Research
New York

Indigenous Groups on-line

Communicating by electronic mail is already a way of life in the Canadian Arctic, where a new semi-autonomous territory known as Nunavut – 'Our Land' in Inuktitut – will officially come into being on April 1, 1999 with the forming of a government. "Nunavut is a new territory that is administratively different from a province," explains Jim Crump, a senior policy analyst working for the Nunavut Planning Commission (NPC). "It is unique in the world: for the first time, a democratic state has created within it a jurisdiction dominated by aboriginal people. It is a form of self-government in which Inuit will be making decisions about issues such as land use and health." The NPC is headed by a nine-member board, including several hunters who live off the land. Dispersed across 350,000 sq. kilometres, they communicate in their own language by e-mail using a syllabic font. Their keys carry stickers representing letters of an alphabet developed for their oral language in recent

years. Meetings with partners from the Canadian Government are also digitized: required information is stocked on a CD-ROM which Board members can load onto their computers and consult in their own language. "It's come with practice," explains Crump, pointing out

Embracing technologies: a matter of survival, and of practice.

© PANOS PICTURES/C. PENN

